DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET A

Psychology / Paper 1

Worked mark scheme · 90 minutes · 35 marks

Answer Questions 1–4 in Sections A and B. In Section C answer either Question 5 or Question 6. Use psychological knowledge and accurate terminology throughout.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

SECTION A

Knowledge and understanding

QUESTION 1 / 4 MARKS

Describe neuroplasticity, using one example to illustrate its role in behaviour.

Worked response. Neuroplasticity is a change in neural organisation or functioning in response to experience, learning or injury. With repeated practice of a new sequence of finger movements, connections in the networks involved can become more efficient. The learner can then execute the sequence more reliably. The example links a change in functioning to a change in behaviour; practice does not imply that an entirely new brain region is created.

Credit. Accept another explained example, such as functional reorganisation during rehabilitation. A statement that people get better with practice needs a neural link. Credit an accurate explanation without demanding a named study.

Markband. 1–2: relevant content is partly described or the example is left unexplained. 3–4: a precise account of the idea explains how a suitable example illustrates it.

QUESTION 2 / 4 MARKS

Explain how a schema can influence the recall of an event. Use one example.

Worked response. A schema organises prior knowledge and expectations. In reconstructing a memory, a person can fill a gap with a detail consistent with those expectations. A visitor who briefly saw a classroom might later recall a whiteboard even though that particular room had none. Prior classroom knowledge supplies a plausible detail rather than an exact record of the scene.

Credit. An example of schema-guided attention at encoding can also explain later recall. Simply defining a schema as a mental framework without showing how it changes what is remembered leaves the application incomplete.

Markband. 1–2: relevant content is partly described or the example is left unexplained. 3–4: a precise account of the idea explains how a suitable example illustrates it.

SECTION B

Application to new situations

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

Trainees learn the same unfamiliar folding sequence in six minutes. One display puts numbered instructions on a separate wall from the diagrams. Another places each instruction next to the matching fold. Both show the same words and pictures. Trainees using the second display usually make fewer sequencing errors on a new sheet.

Explain how cognitive load theory could account for this difference.

Worked response. Working memory has limited capacity for processing unfamiliar interacting elements. In the first room a trainee must retain a step, find its matching diagram and keep track of the fold while switching attention. That search adds extraneous processing to the demands of the folding task itself. Placing each instruction beside the relevant fold removes much of this search, leaving resources to organise the sequence. The trainee can then apply the steps with fewer errors on the new sheet.

Credit. Reward links to the unchanged task and the changed arrangement. The second display need not increase working-memory capacity. A competing explanation is permissible, but it does not replace applying the requested theory.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant idea is named or applied in a limited way. 3–4: mostly accurate theory explains some features of this case. 5–6: detailed, accurate theory explains the distinctive pattern or contrast in the situation.

QUESTION 4 / 6 MARKS

At a depot most drivers privately favour moving a meeting. When the supervisor asks for a show of hands after three respected drivers publicly oppose the move, several supporters keep their hands down. In an anonymous vote later that day they support the move again. They had already understood both options.

Explain how conformity could account for the change between the public and anonymous responses.

Worked response. In public the first speakers make opposition look like the group norm. Drivers who want acceptance, or wish to avoid appearing disloyal in front of respected colleagues, can publicly match it while keeping their private preference. An anonymous vote removes much of that social cost. The return to the original preference fits normative conformity and public compliance. Information about the options did not change, so assuming that all drivers privately accepted the majority view fits the observations less well.

Credit. Accept another coherent account of conformity if it explains the timing, visibility and contrast in responses. Repeating that the supervisor has authority without addressing group influence does not fully apply the concept.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant idea is named or applied in a limited way. 3–4: mostly accurate theory explains some features of this case. 5–6: detailed, accurate theory explains the distinctive pattern or contrast in the situation.

SECTION C

Conceptual essays · choose one

QUESTION 5 / 15 MARKS

Discuss the concept of change with reference to stage theories and continuous models of cognitive development.

Worked argument. A stage explanation predicts a qualitative reorganisation of thinking, rather than simply more correct answers. For instance, success on a conservation task may reflect coordinating two dimensions instead of attending only to height. Its strongest prediction concerns a coherent shift in reasoning across related tasks. A continuous model can explain improvement through gradually increasing working-memory capacity, knowledge or strategy efficiency. A slowly improving skill can cross a task threshold abruptly, so a sudden pass does not establish a new stage.

Testing the accounts. Compare performance by the same child on several tasks over time and ask for explanations as well as answers. Consistent changes in the reasoning used across tasks would strengthen a stage interpretation. Earlier success when wording or memory demands are reduced, or progress at different rates across tasks, strengthens a gradual, task-sensitive account. Repeated testing can itself change strategies; a cross-sectional age difference alone cannot reveal an individual's path.

Judgement. Stage descriptions can capture reorganisations that matter to teachers while continuous models can explain how those reorganisations emerge. The better account depends on whether change refers to a process, a score or a pattern across domains. Credit a reasoned defence of either model which identifies evidence that could distinguish it from the alternative.

Markband. 1–3: isolated content with little bearing on the concept. 4–6: a mainly descriptive account with a partial conceptual link. 7–9: relevant knowledge and some analysis, but the argument or conclusion is incomplete. 10–12: developed critical analysis connects the concept, psychology and context and supports a judgement. 13–15: sustained, precise conceptual reasoning weighs competing interpretations and supports a nuanced judgement throughout.

QUESTION 6 / 15 MARKS

Discuss the role of measurement in explaining reported differences in the prevalence of one mental health disorder between populations.

Worked argument. For depression, prevalence counts people meeting a defined criterion within a specified population and period. A screening score, an interview-based diagnosis and a clinic record can produce different estimates. Consider two populations with identical underlying levels of distress. If one language version translates a low-mood item poorly, equivalent experiences can produce different scores. A common numerical cut-off then standardises the decision rule without establishing that the scores mean the same thing.

Alternative explanations. Clinic data can also miss people without affordable care or those reluctant to disclose symptoms. Representative sampling, comparable reference periods and locally validated interviews can reduce these differences. A culturally adapted measure may improve local validity while making direct comparison harder. Real exposure to adversity or protective support may still differ; measurement bias cannot be inferred merely because two estimates are unequal.

Judgement. A prevalence difference is more convincing when multiple methods agree and groups have comparable access to assessment. Where a difference shrinks after comparable interviews replace clinic counts, ascertainment becomes a stronger explanation. A high-quality answer distinguishes the population, the underlying construct and the observed count and reaches a conditional conclusion.

Markband. 1–3: isolated content with little bearing on the concept. 4–6: a mainly descriptive account with a partial conceptual link. 7–9: relevant knowledge and some analysis, but the argument or conclusion is incomplete. 10–12: developed critical analysis connects the concept, psychology and context and supports a judgement. 13–15: sustained, precise conceptual reasoning weighs competing interpretations and supports a nuanced judgement throughout.